PUNJABI COLLECTION

NO. 07



PUNJAB & NORTH INDIA ORIGIN

Rajma Masala

Red Kidney Bean Curry

The Sunday Lunch Every North Indian Knows

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

LICENSE & COPYRIGHT NOTICE

Rajma Masala

Sold via: Gumroad
Publisher: DhanioDigital (dhaniodigital.gumroad.com)

PERSONAL USE LICENSE

This digital cookbook is licensed for personal, non-commercial use only.
You may print one (1) copy for your own kitchen use.

YOU MAY NOT:

- Share, resell, or redistribute this file in any form
- Upload to any website, cloud service, or file-sharing platform
- Remove or obscure any watermarks, copyright notices, or branding
- Use recipes for commercial food service without written permission

Violation of this license may result in legal action.

© 2024 DhanioDigital. All rights reserved.
Contact: support@dhaniodigital.com

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Rajma Masala

AUTHOR

Sweta Verma

PUBLISHER

DhanioDigital

COPYRIGHT

© 2026 Sweta Verma. All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced or distributed without written permission from the publisher.

DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Comfort Food of Sunday Afternoons

Rajma chawal — kidney bean curry served over rice — holds a place in North Indian households that's hard to overstate: for generations, it has been the unofficial Sunday lunch of Punjabi and Delhi families, the dish mothers make when everyone is finally home together and there's time for a long, slow-cooked meal. Rajma masala, the curry itself, is the heart of that tradition.

The bean's cultivation history in India is relatively recent compared to older pulses like chickpeas and lentils — kidney beans were introduced to the subcontinent from the Americas following European contact, and took hold particularly well in the cooler climates of Kashmir and the Himalayan foothills, from where they spread into Punjabi and North Indian cooking more broadly.

What makes rajma masala beloved isn't complexity — it's the opposite. A humble, everyday curry of tomatoes, onions, and warming spices, given time to slowly meld with the beans until the whole dish becomes something greater than its simple parts, evoking the specific comfort of a lazy Sunday at home more than almost any other North Indian dish.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Comfort Food of Sunday Afternoons, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

The centerpiece of "rajma chawal," the quintessential North Indian Sunday lunch tradition. Kidney beans arrived in India via European trade contact and took root especially well in Kashmir and the Himalayan foothills. A humble, everyday comfort dish rather than a special-occasion curry, valued precisely for its familiar, homestyle simplicity. Widely considered one of the most nostalgic dishes for North Indians living away from home.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	8h + 40m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	SOAK + COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Pressure cooker (strongly recommended)
- Kadai or wide, heavy-bottomed pan for the gravy
- Wooden spoon or spatula

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Rajma masala keeps refrigerated for up to 5 days and is well known for tasting even better the next day, as the beans continue absorbing the gravy's flavor. It freezes excellently for up to 3 months, making it a highly practical make-ahead dish for batch cooking.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the beans

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Red kidney beans (rajma), dried	1½ cups	300 g	1½ katori
Water, for soaking and cooking	as needed	as needed	as needed
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

For the masala gravy

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Oil or ghee	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Onion, finely chopped	1 large	150 g	1 large
Ginger-garlic paste	1½ tbsp	22 g	1½ chammach
Tomatoes, pureed	3 medium	300 g	3 medium
Coriander powder	1½ tsp	4.5 g	1½ chammach
Kashmiri red chili powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Garam masala	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Salt	to taste	to taste	to taste
Fresh coriander, chopped, for garnish	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Canned kidney beans are a genuinely good shortcut for this dish — use two 15 oz / 400 g cans, drained and rinsed, and reduce the cooking time significantly since they're already tender. Kashmiri red chili powder gives good color with mild heat; substitute sweet paprika with a small pinch of cayenne if unavailable. This is one of the more universally accessible dishes in the collection, using ingredients found in most well-stocked grocery stores worldwide.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Beans

01 SOAK OVERNIGHT

Rinse the dried kidney beans and soak in plenty of water overnight, or for at least 8 hours, until roughly doubled in size.

02 PRESSURE COOK UNTIL SOFT

Drain and pressure cook the soaked beans with fresh water and salt for 6–8 whistles, until completely soft and easily mashed between two fingers.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Beans, continued

Chef tip. keep the bean cooking liquid — it's flavorful and useful for adjusting the final gravy's consistency.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The beans are ready when they mash easily under light pressure and the skins have softened completely, with no firm or chalky centers remaining.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Masala Gravy

03 BLOOM THE CUMIN

Heat oil or ghee in a kadai and add the cumin seeds, letting them sizzle for a few seconds until fragrant.

04 SAUTÉ THE ONIONS

Add the chopped onion and sauté until deeply golden brown, about 8 minutes. Stir in the ginger-garlic paste and cook until fragrant.

05 ADD TOMATO AND SPICES

Pour in the tomato puree along with the coriander powder, chili powder, and garam masala. Simmer for 10–12 minutes, until the mixture thickens and the oil separates slightly at the edges.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Masala Gravy, continued



06 COMBINE WITH THE BEANS

Add the cooked kidney beans to the gravy, along with some of the reserved cooking liquid to reach your preferred consistency. Simmer together for 20–25 minutes, mashing a few beans against the side of the pan to help thicken the gravy naturally.

Texture indicator. rajma masala should be thick and rich, with some beans holding their shape and others broken down into the gravy for body.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Masala Gravy, continued

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Serving rajma right after the beans finish cooking, without simmering them properly in the gravy, misses the whole point of the dish. Give the beans and gravy at least 20 minutes together for the flavors to fully meld.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot over steamed basmati rice — "rajma chawal" — the classic Sunday lunch combination.
- Garnished with fresh coriander and served with a side of plain yogurt and sliced onion.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl alongside a mound of rice, with a small side of pickle and papad.

Family Style

- A large shared pot at the center of a relaxed Sunday family lunch, ladled generously over individual rice plates.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Flavor Right

- Well-caramelized onions build significant depth — don't rush this step, even though it's tempting to.
- Mashing a portion of the beans into the gravy thickens it naturally and gives the dish its characteristic hearty texture.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Rajma masala is an ideal make-ahead dish — many households consider it best made a day in advance.
- Cook a large batch of beans and freeze in portions for quick future meals — just make the gravy fresh each time.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks add a small piece of butter and a pinch of garam masala right at the very end, off the heat, for a final layer of aroma just before serving — a small touch that makes a noticeable difference.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

260 kcal	13 g	38 g	6 g	12 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with cream, butter, and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Punjabi Rajma	the classic version featured here, with a tomato-onion base and warming spices.
Kashmiri Rajma	a variation reflecting the bean's strong culinary presence in the Kashmir valley, often with a slightly different spice profile.
Restaurant-Style Rajma	enriched with extra butter and sometimes a touch of cream for a richer finish.

Can I use canned kidney beans?

Yes — use two 15 oz / 400 g cans, drained and rinsed, skipping the soaking step and simmering directly in the gravy for about 20 minutes.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why is my rajma thin and watery?

Usually not enough simmering time with the gravy, or not mashing any beans to help thicken it naturally. Give it more time and mash a portion against the pan.

Is rajma masala the same everywhere in North India?

The base technique is similar, but spicing and thickness vary by household and region — Punjabi versions tend to be richer, while some other regional styles are lighter and more tomato-forward.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Rajma	Hindi for red kidney beans, the base ingredient of this dish.
Chawal	Hindi for rice, the traditional and essential pairing for this curry.
Rajma Chawal	the classic combination of this curry served over rice.
Garam Masala	a warming whole-spice blend added toward the end of cooking for aroma.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Rajma Masala

15m	8h + 40m
ACTIVE PREP	SOAK + COOK TIME
4	**Easy**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

BEANS

Red kidney beans	300 g
Water	as needed
Salt	6 g

MASALA GRAVY

Oil or ghee	45 ml
Cumin seeds	4 g
Onion	150 g
Ginger-garlic paste	22 g
Tomatoes	300 g
Coriander powder	4.5 g
Kashmiri red chili powder	3 g
Garam masala	3 g
Salt	to taste
Fresh coriander	8 g

METHOD

01 **Soak overnight.** Rinse the dried kidney beans and soak in plenty of water overnight, or for at least 8 hours, until roughly doubled in size.

02 **Pressure cook until soft.** Drain and pressure cook the soaked beans with fresh water and salt for 6–8 whistles, until completely soft and easily mashed between two fingers.

03 **Bloom the cumin.** Heat oil or ghee in a kadai and add the cumin seeds, letting them sizzle for a few seconds until fragrant.

04 **Sauté the onions.** Add the chopped onion and sauté until deeply golden brown, about 8 minutes.

05 **Add tomato and spices.** Pour in the tomato puree along with the coriander powder, chili powder, and garam masala.

06 **Combine with the beans.** Add the cooked kidney beans to the gravy, along with some of the reserved cooking liquid to reach your preferred consistency.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐	Red kidney beans	300 g	
☐	Oil or ghee	45 ml	
☐	Onion	150 g	
☐	Tomatoes	300 g	
☐	Kashmiri red chili powder	3 g	
☐	Fresh coriander	8 g	
☐	Salt	see recipe	
☐	Cumin seeds	4 g	
☐	Ginger-garlic paste	22 g	
☐	Coriander powder	4.5 g	
☐	Garam masala	3 g	

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com